

Tracking Changes

The Literary “Canon” & Bestsellers in Circulation

*Icelyn Dai,
Colin Purtell,
& Lucas Rosendall*



Presentation Roadmap

01

Introduction & Data Overview

Three datasets spanning library holdings, checkouts, and bestsellers

02

Analysis Summary

Methods and key findings

03

Conclusions & Implications

Implications for understanding literary canonicity and public circulation

Data Overview

The Objectives

Which canonical authors might the public still be reading? What motivates audiences to reach for a particular novel, canonical or otherwise? How might the circulation of canonized books compare to the circulation of bestsellers? Reading & reception data is hard to come by, but our project seeks to investigate relationships between canonicity & real-world circulation.

Top 500 Canonical Novels

A ranked list of the 500 most critically acclaimed novels, with bibliographic metadata, OCLC library holdings, and Goodreads ratings.

Seattle Public Library

A monthly count of Seattle Public Library checkouts by title for physical and electronic items. 50M+ Checkout Records

International Bestsellers Post45

Weekly bestseller list data aggregated across multiple countries, tracking commercially successful titles and their author

gr_avg_rating

oclc_holdings

spl_checkouts

title

author

avg_monthly_che...

genre

Analysis Summary

Analytical Method

Why Classification?

**How canonized books
relate to contemporary
readership and
popularity**



**Identify and predict
patterns in book popularity
by categorizing outcomes:**

- High circulation
- Bestseller status

Analytical Method

1

Define target variables

- High circulation: checkout count above median
- Bestseller: matched in international bestseller dataset

2

Feature preparation

- Applied log transformation to skewed variables
- Engineered metadata and popularity features
- Encoded categorical variables

3

Data splitting

- Stratified train-test split to preserve class balance

Analytical Method

4

Model training

- Logistic Regression, Random Forest, Gradient Boosting, KNN, Decision Tree

5

Model tuning

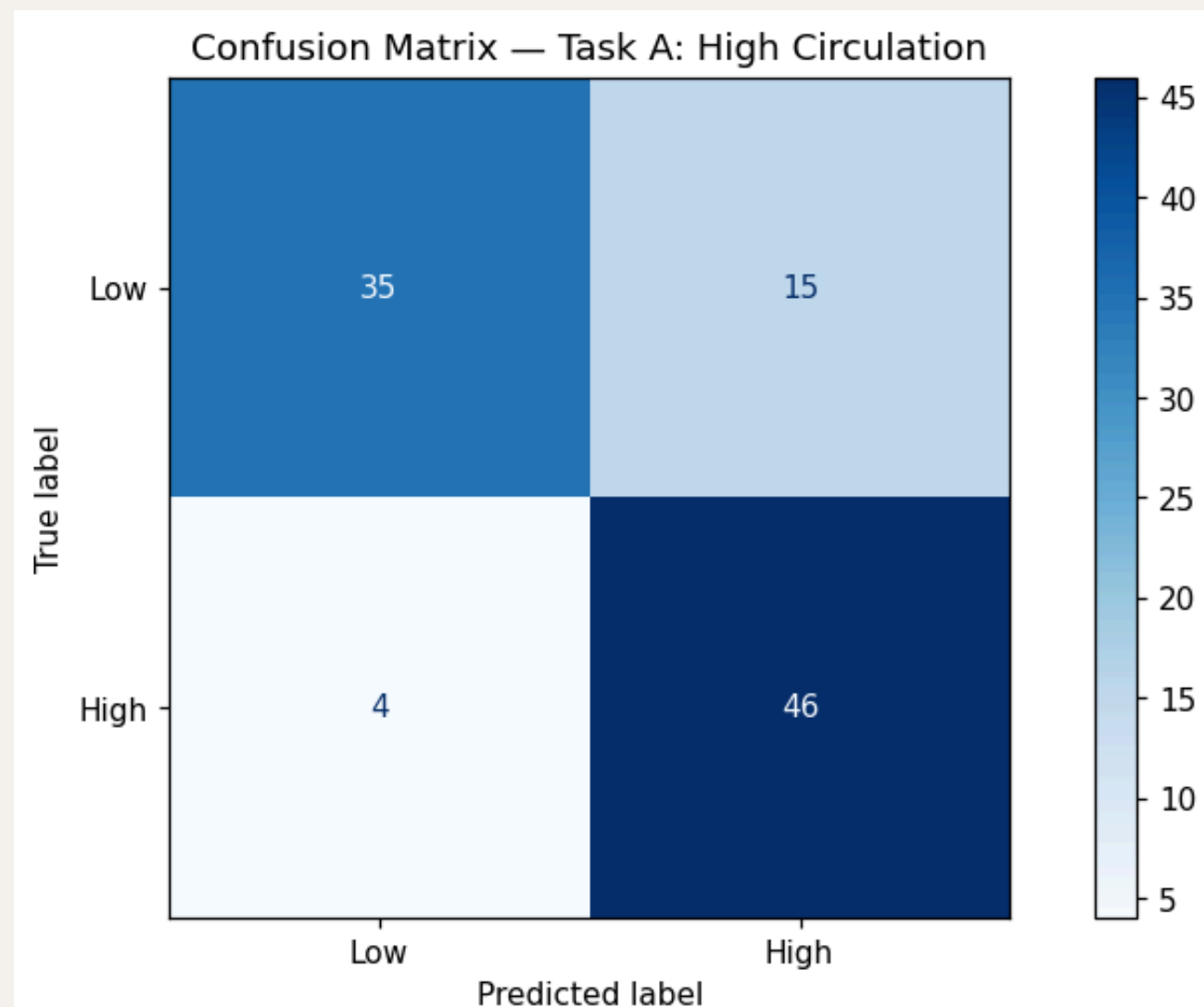
- Hyperparameter optimization using GridSearchCV
- 5-fold cross-validation

6

Evaluation

- Metrics: Accuracy, ROC-AUC, Precision, Recall, F1-score

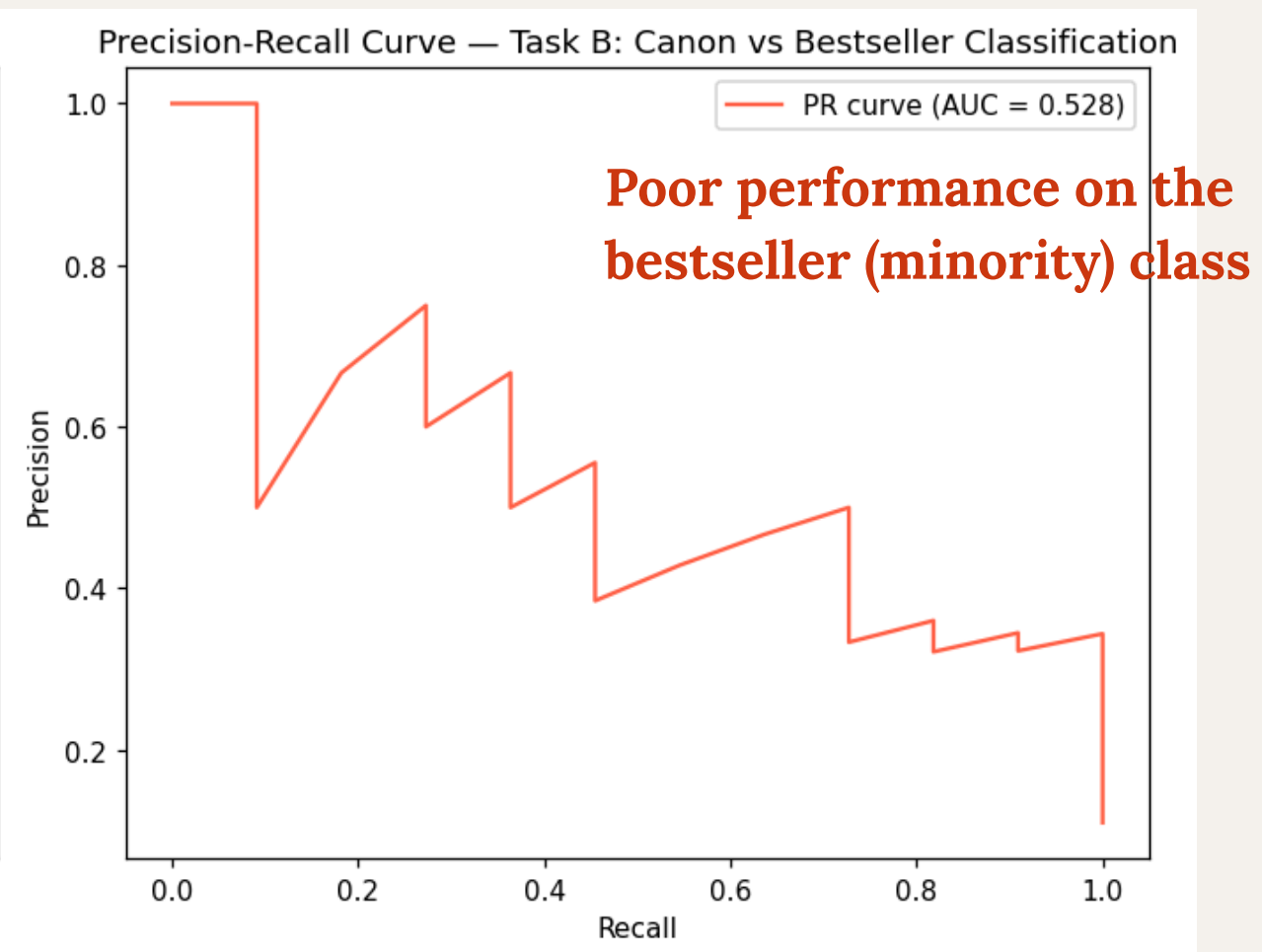
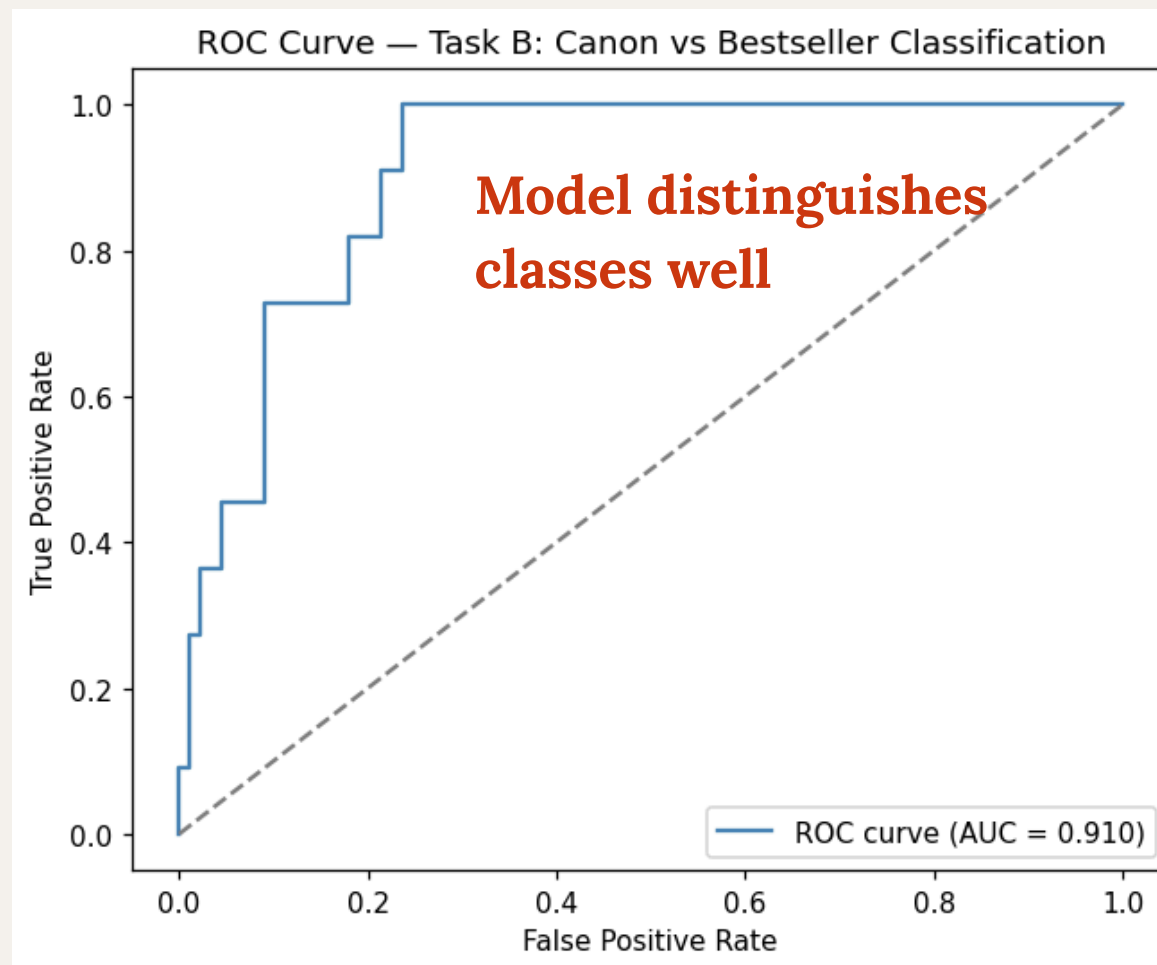
Task A: Are canonized books still circulating?



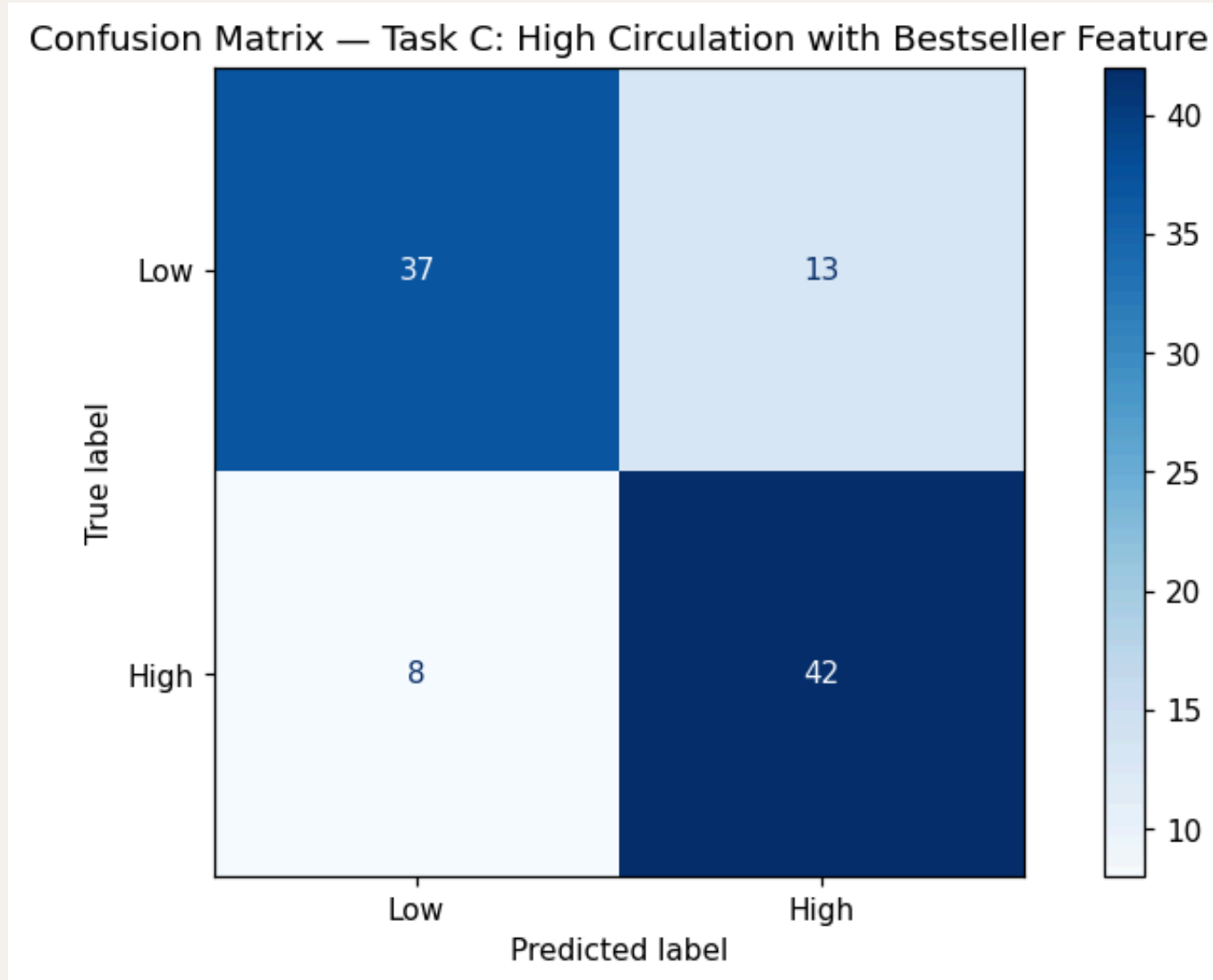
- High recall for high-circulation books (≈ 0.92)
- It slightly overestimates circulation, labeling some low-circulation books as high

Analysis Summary

Task B: Canon vs bestseller classification



Task C: Canon & Bestseller Combined Analysis



- The model still performs well in detecting active books, but slightly worse than Task A
- More missed high-circulation books.

Including bestseller information does not improve the model's ability to identify highly circulated canonized books.

Key Findings

Across all three tasks, the results consistently show that canonical significance and contemporary popularity are related but distinct dimensions of literary success.

1

Canonized books continue to circulate, but unevenly

2

Bestseller status reflects modern global popularity, but is rare among canonical works.

3

The overlap between the two is limited, with only a subset of books achieving both high circulation and bestseller status

Main Conclusions

The strongest conclusions came not only from what the model predicted, but from what it could not explain.

1

Bestseller status was a weaker predictor than expected

2

Canonical recognition does not guarantee equal readership

3

Our models reveal patterns, but not the full story

Why This Matters

**Libraries help
reproduce the canon**

**Commercial success ≠
cultural longevity**

**Public circulation
reflects institutional
access**

**Literary value is
shaped by systems, not
just readers**



Thank You!

